

What is it?

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- **Diabetes mellitus** is a metabolic disorder characterized by persistent hyperglycaemia (random plasma glucose more than 11 mmol/L) with disturbances of carbohydrate, protein, and fat metabolism resulting from defects in insulin secretion (leading to insulin deficiency), insulin action (leading to insulin resistance), or both.
- **In type 1 diabetes**, an absolute insulin deficiency causes persistent hyperglycaemia.
 - The term 'type 1 diabetes' has replaced the older terms 'insulin-dependent diabetes mellitus (IDDM)' and 'juvenile-onset diabetes' because the older terms are potentially misleading: type 1 diabetes can also develop during adulthood and some people with type 2 diabetes are treated with insulin.
- **Other types of diabetes include:**
 - **Type 2 diabetes** — insulin resistance and a relative insulin deficiency result in persistent hyperglycaemia. See the CKS topic on [Diabetes – type 2 \(/topics/diabetes-type-2/\)](#) for more information.
 - **Gestational diabetes** — hyperglycaemia develops during pregnancy and usually resolves after delivery, although the woman is at increased risk for overt type 2 diabetes in the future.
 - **Other specific types of diabetes, including:**
 - Monogenic diabetes (due to a single gene defect; previously known as 'maturity-onset diabetes in the young').
 - Diabetes secondary to pathological conditions or diseases (such as pancreatitis, trauma, or pancreatic surgery).
 - Drug- or chemically-induced diabetes (such as from long-term corticosteroids or antipsychotics).

[NICE, 2016a ([/topics/diabetes-type-1/references/](#)); SIGN, 2017 ([/topics/diabetes-type-1/references/](#)); WHO, 2019 ([/topics/diabetes-type-1/references/](#))]

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